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Strings and their melodic nuances
S. Nithyasree explored the richness of ragas and talas in her veena recital **p2**

Marathi theatre loses a titan
Vijaya Mehta leaves an indelible mark on the contemporary stage **p4**



THE BEST OF ROSSINI, PUCCINI AND VIVALDI
SOI Chamber Orchestra will bring Italian classics to Mumbai's NCPA **p5**

Teejan Bai, who passed away recently, defied patriarchy to take Pandavani from the village square to the world stage

Folk's fearless voice



What is Pandavani

- It is an ancient folk storytelling and ballad-singing tradition from Chhattisgarh that recounts episodes from the *Mahabharata*.
- The lead performer sings and narrates tales in a local dialect, slipping effortlessly into different characters.
- The artiste carries an ektara adorned with peacock feathers and bells. More than a musical instrument, it transforms into a prop as the story unfolds.
- The lead narrator is supported by musicians playing instruments such as the harmonium, tabla, dholak and manjira.

Trailblazer Teejan Bai performing at Ranga Shankara in Bengaluru in 2010. PHOTO: K. BHAGYA PRAKASH

Chitra Swaminathan
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“**A**b hum lipishtick bhi lagate hain. Gaon mein koi kuch nahin bolta. Kyunki ab paisa aur naam jo aa gaya (I now even wear lipstick. People in my village don't comment because today I have money and fame),” says a young Teejan Bai as she applies a bright red shade sitting in a makeshift green room before her performance on an open-air stage in Nagpur. “*Aapko pata hai hum Aumrica jane wale hain* (you know, I will be going to America),” she informs excitedly, and it is hard to miss the glint in her heavily kohl-lined eyes. Unlike her powerful narration on stage, Teejan speaks in a measured tone. As she recalls her arduous journey, dabbing some rose powder on her cheeks, she explains that makeup is more than an adornment; it is often a veil, masking years of pain and humiliation endured in her quest for acceptance in the male-dominated world of Pandavani (stories of the Pandavas). The folk art form largely remained unknown until she emerged as its foremost exponent.

However, it would be grossly unfair to attribute Teejan's success solely to her mastery of the art form. Her greatest achievement lay in drawing global attention, in a cultural landscape where classical arts have long enjoyed institutional patronage, to a folk tradition. Equally significant was her refusal to dilute its rustic charm or compromise its intrinsic Chhattisgarhi flavour, even when performing on some of the world's most prestigious stages. The dialect, costume and raw dynamism of the form remained intact, irrespective of the setting. “Believe it or not, I was beaten by my parents when I first expressed a desire to learn Pandavani,” she says. “I was fascinated by it since childhood. Growing up, I had seen my maternal grandfather perform and memorised most stories from the *Mahabharata* simply by listening to them,” she shares, crediting him for teaching her in secret despite staunch opposition. “My parents thought the only way to stop me was to get me married. But they didn't realise that I would never let anything come between me and my art. I was a born fighter,” she says breaking into a childlike laugh. Teejan was only 12 when she was married. Undeterred, she gave her first public performance at the age of 13. She eventually faced social ostracism, walked out of an abusive marriage and lived alone in a hut. While many believed she had brought disrepute to the community, a few kind neighbours offered her food during those trying times.

“When the whole world, including my near and dear ones, turned hostile, I took refuge in Pandavani. After all, I took on the world for its sake. I would practice day and night. I was my own teacher,” she says, smiling as she picks a few betel leaves from a damp cloth and deftly tucks them into her mouth. Once on stage, Teejan transformed into the many characters from the epic through fierce voice modulation, traversing octaves with remarkable ease. Whether performing in urban auditoria or village squares, she held audiences spellbound. During her presentations, she seemed unfazed by the epic's literary and historical sweep. Equally significant was her choice of performance style. Rejecting the more restrained Vedamati tradition, where the artiste remains seated, she went in for Kapalik, an energetic and

physically demanding form that had long been the preserve of men. “Since they had labelled me a rebel, I thought, why not prove it in every way,” she quips. “So I chose Kapalik because it gives you the freedom to improvise. Have you seen how I turn my ektara into a prop for different episodes? At one moment it is a *gada* (mace), at another a *baan* (arrow) and sometimes even becomes Krishna's bansuri.” Teejan rarely missed an opportunity to perform or speak about the art form. For years, she was a regular at SPIC MACAY (Society for the Promotion of Indian Classical Music and Culture Amongst Youth), enthusiastically showcasing Pandavani at schools and colleges. She understood that such efforts were essential if the folk tradition was to become part of the country's mainstream cultural conversation. Guiding and encouraging her in this endeavour was theatre legend Habib Tanvir, who pioneered a theatre movement rooted in Chhattisgarh's folk forms. He saw in Teejan the potential to transform the way folk art was perceived. Many literary interpretations of the *Mahabharata* may have emerged over the centuries, but folk forms such as Pandavani remain among the most powerful ways of taking the epic to the masses. The dramatic oral recitation of the stories creates an emotional impact that few written retellings can match. It is perhaps no surprise that Draupadi was one of Teejan's favourite characters in the epic. She often infused the episodes centring on her with impromptu verses and intense drama. “I think characters like her are there in the epic to inspire women like me. Draupadi taught me to fight and define myself. Once I faced gender bias, now men perform alongside me,” she says. From earning ₹10 for her first show to receiving the Padma Vibhushan, Teejan Bai carried Pandavani from the villages of Chhattisgarh to audiences across the world, setting an enduring example of resilience and self-belief.



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Retracing Dikshitar’s journey

R. Suryaprakash brought out different aspects of the composer’s kritis



Thematic
R. Suryaprakash performing at The Music Academy.
PHOTO: M. SRINATH

Renuka Suryanarayanan

Vocalist R. Suryaprakash presented a 90-minute Dikshitar-day endowment concert at The Music Academy recently. He focused on nostalgia and

nuance as he sang one composition after another, embellished with manodharma suites. Many aspects of Muthuswami Dikshitar’s brilliance, as a composer, were brought to the fore. The vocalist was accompanied by S.R. Mahadevasarma on the

violin and Guru Raghavendra on the mridangam. Apart from his effusive delineations of Brindavana Saranga and Husseni, what stood out were his explanations of every piece. Suryaprakash began with ‘Subrahmanya

Dikshitar’s kshetra kritis are celebrated for their detailed portrayals of temples, alongside their lyrical praise of the deities.

rakshito(a)ham,’ evoking memories of legendary artistes who made this Dikshitar piece in raga Suddha Dhanyasi iconic. Quick rounds of kalpanaswaras at the pallavi, with the violinist following suit, were an effective warm-up to the evening. The kshetram for this song was Kazhugumalai, said the singer. Much of Dikshitar’s repertoire was inspired by his travels to temples.

Suryaprakash next rendered ‘Krishnananda mukunda’ (raga Ganapathiraman on the mridangam and B.S. Purushotham on the kanjira. The recital commenced with the Nattakurinji pada varnam ‘Chalamela’, followed by Harikesanallur Muthiah Bhagavata’s ‘Gam ganapate’ in Hamsadhwani. Kalpanaswaras, rendered in two speeds, added vitality to the composition. Nithyasree then explored Jaganmohini through a brief raga alapana before presenting Tyagaraja’s ‘Sobillu saptaswara’.

The accompanying swara passages were rendered in two speeds, though the second-speed patterns occasionally tended towards repetition. A change in pace came with a leisurely chowka kala rendition of Muthuswami Dikshitar’s ‘Kamalamba samrakshitoham’ in Anandabhairavi. The sub-main of the evening was Lathangi. Nithyasree offered an expansive alapana that highlighted the raga’s many characteristic panchama-varjya and shadja-varjya phrases, while traversing all three octaves with ease. The gradual movement, between the lower, middle and upper registers, contributed to the raga’s sense of expansiveness and helped sustain the listener’s interest. This was followed by Patnam Subramania Iyer’s kriti ‘Marivere’ (Khanda Chapu tala),

The performer then moved to Husseni raga alapana with distinct phrasings that need to be repeated in order to maintain the raga swaroota or raga identity. ‘Sri kalahastisa’ in this raga is a sthala kriti praising Shiva, who manifests himself as Vayu Linga at this temple. The song concluded with swara rendering at the pallavi.

The highlight of the concert was a Thirumangai Azhwar pasuram followed by the composition ‘Soundara rajam ashraye,’ (raga Brindavana Saranga). The niraval at ‘Tumburu nuta shree kantam duritaapaha vaikuntam,’ resonated with the audience. An in-depth exposition of Kalyani raga followed. The grahamadam at Rishabam was an impressive attempt. The violinist, not to be left behind, scored during his Kalyani raga essay. The song rendered was ‘Abhayamba jagadamba’.

The swaraprastara at the pallavi comprised different endings and was replete with panchama-shadja varja prayoga. Mridangist Guru Raghavendra played a tani embellishing the two-kalai Adi tala structure of this song. The concert ended with a Dikshitar kriti in praise of Ganga.

Laudable Lathangi

S. Nithyasree’s expansive alapana highlighted the myriad facets of the raga

N.C. Srinivasaraghavan

S. Nithyasree presented a veena recital at Narada Gana Sabha under the Mangalam Muthuswamy Veena Endowment series. She was accompanied by B. Ganapathiraman on the mridangam and B.S. Purushotham on the kanjira.

The recital commenced with the Nattakurinji pada varnam ‘Chalamela’, followed by Harikesanallur Muthiah Bhagavata’s ‘Gam ganapate’ in Hamsadhwani. Kalpanaswaras, rendered in two speeds, added vitality to the composition. Nithyasree then explored Jaganmohini through a brief raga alapana before presenting Tyagaraja’s ‘Sobillu saptaswara’.

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embellished with kalpanaswaras. The Lathangi segment stood out for its poise and control.

Madhyamavati was the main raga of the evening. While the alapana displayed a free-flowing approach, a more structured exploration centred on some of the raga’s defining phrases might have enhanced its impact. The tanam that followed was more concise, though the increased tempo occasionally affected its clarity and control. Tyagaraja’s ‘Rama katha sudha’ was the kriti, with the niraval at ‘Dharmadhyakhila’ followed by kalpanaswaras, in two speeds. The swara exchanges were neatly executed, and the concluding swara passages incorporated imaginative kanakku patterns and jantai prayogas, adding complexity. The progression, from the sub-main Lathangi to the more elaborate Madhyamavati, provided a clear sense of build-up in the latter half of the recital.

Throughout her concert, Nithyasree demonstrated a willingness to engage extensively with manodharma and displayed diversity in talas. At times, however, a slightly more measured pace in the compositions may have enabled greater precision in rhythmic alignment.

The concert concluded with Dharmapuri Subbaraya Iyer’s Khamas javali ‘Marubari talalenura’. Ganapathiraman and Purushotham supported the recital with restraint and sensitivity, adapting well to the varying demands of the programme.



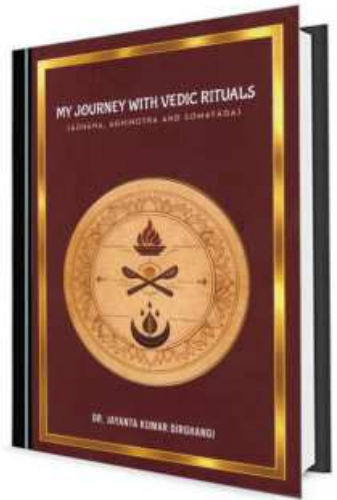
Dual callings

Dr. J.K. Dirghangi reflects on his parallel journeys as a physician and practitioner of vedic rituals in his book

Radha Raghunathan

For many, vedic rituals may seem tedious, but Dr. Jayanta Kumar Dirghangi has spent a lifetime exploring their deeper significance. Dirghangi, a U.S.-based obstetrician and gynaecologist, has long been passionate about Agnihotra, a sacrificial ritual, practising it for several years. In his book, *My Journey with Vedic Rituals (Ādhāna, Agnihotra and Somayāga)*, released earlier this year by Purushottam Publishers, he recounts his journey to becoming a Nitya-agnihotrin and a vedic ritualist.

Hailing from a Bengali family of priests, Dirghangi nurtured his interest in vedic rituals despite the demands of his medical profession. He travelled extensively to study under various Shrauta masters



and was initiated into the Apastamba Agnihotra tradition in Tamil Nadu in 2000 by scholar Agnihotram Ramanuja Tathachariar. The latter not only mentored Dirghangi but also officiated him as the head at his first Somayaga in Gujarat. Later, the teacher, a centenarian by then, encouraged Dirghangi to write a practical guide to Agnihotra. The doctor says the book is a tribute to his guru.

The chapters in the book also serve as a practical manual for the practice of Agnihotra and the performance of complex vedic rituals in the Apastamba tradition. Yet, Dirghangi is quick to remind readers that Agnihotra and other vedic rites are not acquired merely through books; they are a *Gurumukhi Vidya*, passed down directly from teacher to student.

A play with a purpose

Koothapiran Navabharath theatres’ *Veera* celebrates the triumph of the human spirit

Chitradeepa Anantharam
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Koothapiran Navabharath Theatres’ Tamil play, *Veera*, written and directed by Vignesh R., and staged at Chennai’s Narada Gana Sabha, resonated well with the audience. The use of a digital background gave the feel of watching a movie.

The play revolves around the life of Veera, a young man who dreams of making it big as a film director. His journey unfolds through cycles of struggle and failure. Success eludes Veera because of a combination of fate and his own impulsive nature and short temper. A leading producer, who initially signs him to direct a film, withdraws the offer and demands the return of the advance payment after Veera gets into an altercation with the producer’s son at a pub.

The setback pushes Veera into a state of depression. He distances himself from his family, which includes his retired father, his wheelchair-bound mother and his college-going sister, further deepening his emotional turmoil.



Even after two years, Veera’s situation remains unchanged; his mother dies, leaving his sister as the family’s sole breadwinner. Concerned about his son’s emotional and mental well-being, Veera’s father suggests that he spend some time at Brindavanam, an ashram in Udhagamandalam run by his family friend, Prabhu. Hoping a fresh start and a chance to heal, Veera agrees to stay at the ashram for a few months.

The life-changing experiences that Veera undergoes at the ashram form the rest of the narrative. There, he meets Lalitha, a young orphan struggling to overcome her

traumatic past, and Pallavi, a hearing-and speech-impaired girl. Inspired by their resilience and courage, Veera decides to capture their stories through a short film.

In a remarkable turn of events, the film receives immense appreciation, earning him international recognition and awards. The success not only revives Veera’s long-lost

dream of becoming a filmmaker but also marks the beginning of his personal and professional transformation.

The play conveys the message that struggles and setbacks in life are not mere obstacles, but experiences that shape an individual’s character and add deeper meaning to life’s journey.

Vignesh Ratnam was convincing as Veera. He

effortlessly portrayed the protagonist’s emotional highs and lows. Dialogues (Rathnam Koothapiran) were sharp, poignant and complemented the narrative effectively. T.P. Sriram, as Bobby, stole the show, offering brilliant comic relief through his perfect timing and lively stage presence. Suresh Cheenu, as the producer, delivered a nuanced and restrained performance. Kudos to Baby Subha (who portrayed Lalitha), and Swathi Sridhar (Pallavi), for their sincere and realistic portrayals.

While *Veera* is driven by a meaningful premise, its first half suffers from a slow pace, and the narrative takes time to engage the audience. The play gathers momentum only after Veera arrives at the ashram, where the story becomes more emotionally compelling. The effective use of digital projections enhanced the visual appeal without overshadowing the performances. It is a production that appeals to family audiences while leaving them with much to reflect upon.

The play is staged again today, 7 p.m. at Mylapore Fine Arts Club


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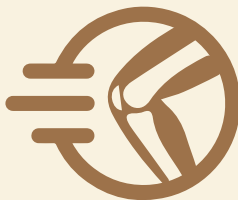
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